Annual Report

FY 2022-23

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'You' included in us makes 'Vayam'

Apne Vikas ka apna abhiyan

Dear friends

It is a pleasure to present and share with you the 16th annual report of Vayam movement. Your contribution has helped us reach further and higher goals with every passing year. It is a time to share the joy with you to multiply it thousandfold.

Vayam has consistently worked to strengthen Gram Sabha; the assembly of all adult villagers that is statutorily recognized. Natural resources; viz. Jal, Jungle, Jameen (Land, forest, water) are the foundation of all primary livelihood of the rural populace we serve. These resources can not be held and harnessed by any individual in isolation. Competition between individuals can bring a disaster to all. Hence, the resources must be managed and governed by the Gram Sabha – a place where all voices can be heard and equality of opportunity can be ensured.

The political system is highly disinterested in empowering a Gram Sabha because of obvious reasons. The constitution and the PESA act vest powers in Gram Sabha. Vayam has brought a synergy between these statutes and the tradition of village assembly in the tribal villages.

The synergy has given wonderful results on many fronts: It has mitigated distress migration. It has enabled the village community spend government funds effectively. It has developed plans and initiated action to protect and conserve biodiversity in community forests. It has built sustainable water bodies satisfying the thirst of humans and cattle. And it has evolved community institutions that shall sustain all the change that is happening.

Belief in intrinsic strength of the people – is the thread that weaves the fabric of oneness called 'Vayam'.

This thread may be invisible in this document. It may look like a series of projects, figures, photographs. These are most apparent: the fruits of our efforts. But you have helped us water the roots, so we thought it apt to share with you both the roots and the fruits.

Happy reading…

Team Vayam
August 25, 2023

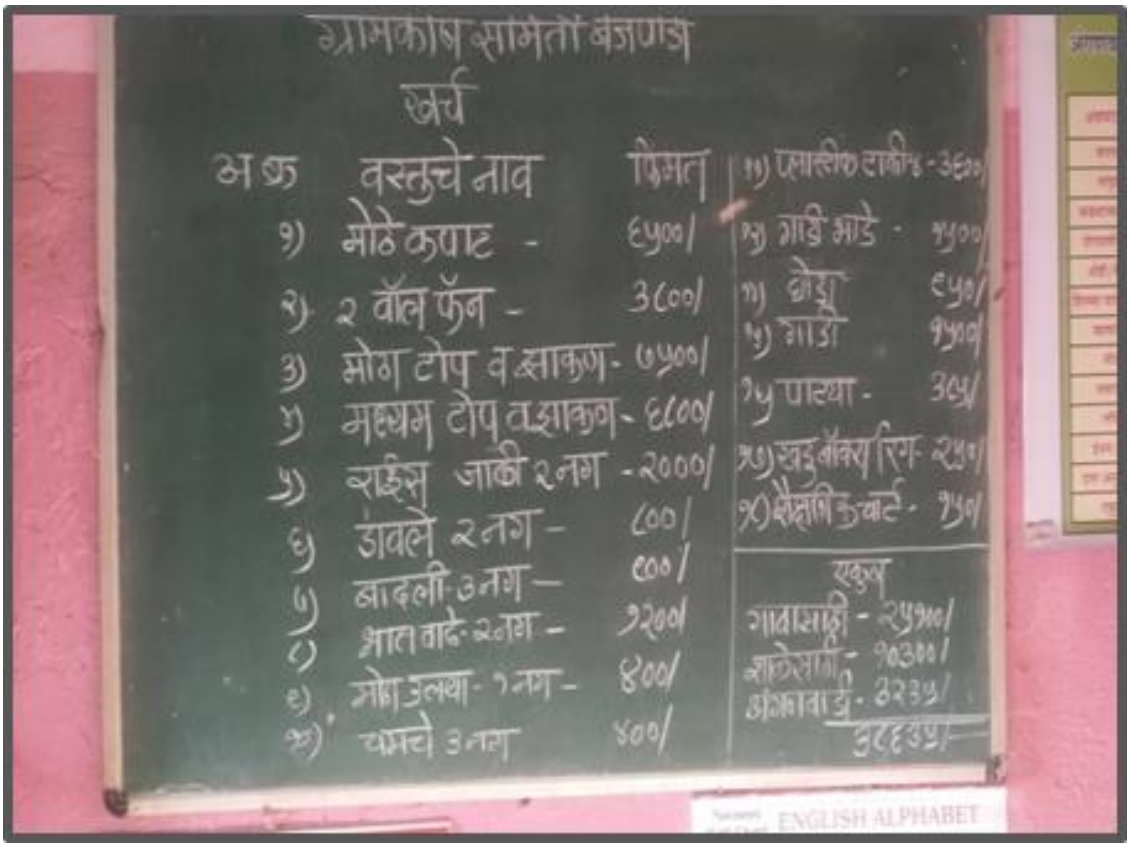
Gramsabha Impact

Vayam has been empowering Gram Sabhas in working on their rights. It is a big shift in the present system where the movement is introducing democracy and self-rule or Swa-Rajya in depth. It's not a denial of current systems Vayam is battling for. The battle is for inclusion of stakeholders in the process of governing resources. It's in our Indic values where Gram Sabhas have been taking care of their resources; Jal-Jungle-Jameen for centuries. At village level as per Gram Panchayat act,1956 and PESA,1996 Gram Sabha is the body which has power of decision-making and control over Gram Panchayat affairs. There is no representation at Gram Sabha level. Every voter is a life-time member of Gram Sabha. PESA bestows on the Gram Sabha, control over natural resources in scheduled areas. The very act has made the Gram Sabhas capable of managing its affairs on its own. The Government of Maharashtra transfers 5% of its Tribal Sub Plan funds to Gram Sabhas in Scheduled Areas.'Padopadi Swarajya' (Swa-raj in smallest village) initiative is completing its successive seventh year. 45+ Gram Sabhas are associated with Vayam movement to take democracy to the next step. So, this year too the Gram Sabhas under the guidance of Vayam have successfully utilized their funds – through participatory decision making and transparency in transactions. They made rules about consumption of select wild edible species. They are learning how to approach the right government official and ask him the right question. They are learning to develop committees to execute its decisions, pursue government offices and staff to

take up works recommended by Gram Sabha. They are learning how to handle Gram Sabha discussions in a manner that every voice would be heard.

Current batch of 18 villages is in the process of learning all these things…

Talukas	Villages	Gram Sabha meetings	Funds utilised by 12 village Sabhas	Number of people attended the training on Committee functions
4	18	142	₹11,86,001	89



Maha-Gathering of Gram Sabhas

While the villages conduct Gram Sabha meetings with utmost honesty and regularity, the bureaucracy often neglects the resolutions they pass. Many works proposed by Gram Sabha remain pending although it's within all legal norms. The Gram Sabhas of many villages experienced this bureaucratic resistance and apathy and this necessitated that they bring their energies together in order to make a sound that can penetrate the deafness of bureaucracy.

Vayam arranged a 'Gram Sabha Mahamelava' wherein thousands of villagers from 104 Gram Sabhas came together. The chief guest was Tribal Minister of Maharashtra State Dr. Vijaykumar Gavit. The common people i.e. members of Gram Sabhas voiced their woes and demands from the dais and the minister promised to fulfill all. People are waiting!

Leadership training

Capacity Building is the core work of Vayam movement. The milestones in capacity building are in the form of training camps and classes arranged regularly. The flagship program is 'Netrutva Shibir' – a 2-day residential leadership training camp where a group of men and women from select villages participate. They learn the basics of laws like Forest Rights Act, NREGA, and PESA. They learn through lots of activities, games, role-plays and so on. The residence together is mainly for bonding and de-crusting of inhibitions.

	Villages	Participants
Residential Netrutva Shibir	12	44
Non-residential Netrutva Shibir	41	99

Monthly Learning circle (अभ्यासवर्ग)

2-3 persons (both men and women) from all villages attend this monthly Abhyas Varg for three hours. There is one lecture in the program, but the bigger part is that of peer learning, cognition to good things done by some villages, and encouragement of leadership. Each Abhyas Varg has a dialogue with bureaucracy; either by inviting the block level officers to the Varg or participants visiting the offices and interacting.

Name of Taluka	Abhyas Vargs	Average attendance
Jawhar	3	12
Mokhada	7	24
Vikramgad	8	21
Trimbakeshwar	11	18

Making representatives People-centric

In democracy politics has to be people-centric, but as we can see it is becoming more and more party-centric. Palghar villages witnessed Gram Panchayat elections last year.

We could observe our Gram Sabhas were more aware of their rights and benefits. They were active in the process of candidate selection to voting.

When it all ended, we suggested Gram Sabhas to invite newly elected Sarpanch to their Gram Sabha meeting. 21 Gram Sabhas implemented the idea. They invited the sarpanch who was even from opposite party at many places and honoured him by offering a Manpatra for his success.

People greeted Sarpanch with good intentions and also made him aware of Gram Sabha rights. In the meetings people expressed their expectations for good and impartial governance. Transparency was one of the main issues which was discussed at length.
It was a good dialogue between people and representatives or more precisely between two constitutional bodies. Vayam was a catalyst as usual.

Forest Rights

Land resource is the most important resource for an individual, a community and a nation. Generally, ownership of an individual can be understood. By now memory of collective ownership and shared duties have been totally forgotten. Villages and communities were well aware of the concept of resource sharing hundreds of years back. They shared the benefits of common properties. Cost of maintenance also used to reduce because of sharing of the responsibilities.

Villages used to pass the information about traditional boundaries of the forest and private land and public land one generation to other. It was a part of collective knowledge. Everybody knows everything about community owned resources. India which has moved away from its roots can understand what were her traditions in past times by observing present forest dwelling communities. Modern way of life has been affecting our traditional heritage of community driven resource sharing systems and Vayam endeavors to redraft the systems in present situation.

Vayam has always believed that the forest-dwelling communities are the primary stakeholders of forest. They depend so heavily on the forest that destruction of a forest is too costly for them. Their daily survival needs like fodder, firewood, medicine, and food are satisfied by the forest. Hence maximum forest area should be handed over to such people i.e., to democratic institutions solely made of forest-dependent communities. This is where the world is leading to. Our neighbours Nepal and Bhutan take pride in having maximum forests being managed by the village communities. India on the contrary continues to boast and bolster a colonial forest department that we inherited with British laws and has been responsible for the massive degradation of forests over last 150 years. The Parliament passed FRA (Forest Rights Act) in 2006 recognizing the forest dwellers' rights and the need to restore justice.

Land security; the basis of livelihood

Vayam has been fighting for the rights of farmers who have been earning their livelihood on forest land since generations. Forest Rights Act,2006 paved a way to get the ownership over the land they have been cultivated. But if not implemented properly even any revolutionary provision cannot make a difference. It was 15th years of Vayam's struggle towards implementing rights of the people.

Struggle in Palghar district

In 2017, 2051 people from Palghar district filed their appeal to district committee against the committee's decision to entitle a smaller piece of land than their holding/claim. Many people have mere 0.25-acre land on their title. Nothing happened despite of constant follow ups in last couple of years.

To let people know about the status of their appeals, in the month of October Vayam called for a mass gathering. Collector of the Palghar district and District level Committee members were invited to address the people. Around 3000 people gathered to have the information about their appeals.

Administration first tried not to allow the gathering under the excuse of election code of conduct. Vayam pleaded that no code of conduct is applicable to common people hence District administration is bound to listen to people and answer the queries. After waiting of three hours Assistant Collector faced the mass gathering and ensured to accelerate the process at subdivision level.

All the appeals are now pending with District committee. District Committee didn't take the decision on their own in all these years. Now they are hiding behind the status quo order of the State Level Monitoring Committee.

So the battleground has shifted. Lobbying at state level is in the process.

Struggle in Nashik district

Vayam is fighting on behalf of 541 farmers in Nashik District as their claims have totally been rejected. A procedure to claim the land under FRA requires some documents as a proof. A rigid bureaucratic mentality fails to understand the rationale behind the proofs. Bureaucracy is expecting an illiterate and ignorant forest dweller to produce a fine receipt issued by a forest department 15 to 30 years back as a sole proof. Nothing can be more comic and tragic. Since 2018, Vayam is fighting the case at subdivision level, then district level and now at division level. To check all the claims carefully was itself a big task. Tracking every claim and helping the claimant to appeal next level is next tedious job team Vayam has been doing.

Vayam keeps all the records transparent and efficient way. Now 80% of the claimants have filed their appeal to division level. 138 claims out of 541 have been sanctioned so far.

Community Forests; Rights with Responsibility

Vayam helped village communities file claims for Community Forest Resource Rights (CFRR). This year after constant follow ups with District Committee nine villages have received titles to such rights. These villages received titles that were pending for one to two years and that too after Vayam complained to the National Commission for Scheduled Tribes about it.

Villages didn't wait for the title of the land to start conservation activities. As we rightly perceive, leaning towards conservation is in our blood. People from 10 villages planted 4015 trees on community owned land. They took care of the plants for entire year. Around 40% of the plants have survived.

A detailed study of the forest resource is completed this year. Although there will always be a scope to go deep, the amount of data gathered is good enough to facilitate an action plan. Children also were involved in the documentation process. All the information is verified, shared and handed over to Gramsabha.

In this study following information is covered:

1. GPS map of entire area under Gramsabha control

2. GPS of all areas within and area profile with slope, soil pattern, list of individual owners in that area, availability of water etc
3. List of all plants, their traditional usage, availability
4. List of forest produce
5. Survey of the families which are involved in selling forest produce
6. Survey of stake holders
7. Medicinal plants and traditional methods to use them.

The select information has been displayed through QR code at the entrance of the village, so it can be accessed easily by anyone. Detailed information is safe with Gramsabhas.

Two villages are still having pending claims because the local bureaucracy has no understanding of the lawful rights and is afraid of taking decisions. It's the National commission of scheduled tribes which is pushing the cases. So, we hope to have the matter solved in coming year.

Educate Empower Employ

Vayam started its work by creating awareness about NREGA. The act not only generates employment but is also capable of creating assets for farmers. Vayam has spread a huge awareness about the rights under this act among vast number of people so far.

This year we tried to take it further. 45% of the villages demanded the work on their own while completing their third year with Vayam. Demanding of work consists of:

- Mobilising village people
- Writing the necessary information correctly
- Submitting the form in Gram Panchayat
- Asking for the receipt

- Submitting the copy to Tehsil Office on not receiving the receipt

All the tasks require courage, conviction, continuance and commitment. This is new leadership emerging on the basis of knowledge. Vayam gave hands-on training of leadership through employment generation activities.

Villages preparing NREGA works plan	37
Camp for registering new Job Cards	19
Villages demanding work	94
Meetings on worksite	97
Number of Workers	3301
Rozgar Samiti formed	10
Meetings of Samities	53
Number of villages demanded for unemployment allowance	4
Everage work-days of work every worker got	48 days

So, to make sure that employment flow continues for years – education and empowerment is the sine qua non.

Methodology designed to achieve this goal is the key. Meeting village initiators twice in a month, meeting every NREGA labourer at least twice during six months, meeting officials at different levels once in a week, assign programme to every village as per their capacity are some of the key features of our methodology.

NREGA: National Rural Employment Guarantee Act: this law guarantees 100-day unskilled labour wage work to every rural citizen on demand

Dhadpad Prayogshala

Education must enable a child to discover herself. Vayam believes in the same philosophy with children as with the grown-ups. We believe that education is not filling something in the empty vessel. Education doesn't mean to start the journey from the zero. We all earn the knowledge of our surrounding from very early age. A child living in a small village may find it difficult to express what he knows. That doesn't mean she doesn't know.

Vayam's education initiatives are based on this concept of understanding things better which we already know. That is education. So, it's like many circles emerging from same center and growing towards infinity.

How do the principles look like when they appear in the form of activity?

We use science as a tool in this journey. 16 sessions based on 7th and 8th science syllabus are designed. They are about their surrounding and human body. Children endeavor to understand their surrounding and their body systems together. For example, children do a survey of how much fast-food is being consumed by children. They also make a list of wild edibles which they

consume during Monsoon. They understand nutrients from both types of food. They also learn how digestive system works through a simple model. Then the whole issue of ‘why fast-food is harmful’ makes sense.

Number of models given to the schools	16
Themes of the models All models have a sticker of QR code which takes to the video links Digestive system, respiratory system, all types of joints, animal cell, plant cell, kaleidoscope, periscope, atom model, soil strata,	

They learn through various methods. Like making models, watching videos, observing things, revisiting their own experiences, doing surveys etc. So the process of transforming information into knowledge begins.

Celebrating Vigyan Diwas

Dhadpad Prayogshala

We took an opportunity of Vigyan Diwas (science day) to let students present what they have learnt.

A group of three students from every school was invited to Vayam's training centre. They learnt the activities they already had done in past year again in new perspective. Now they had to teach the activities to other fellow students from their class. Then they all would demonstrate the models and explain its

functioning to younger students of the school.

Total 61 students from 24 schools gathered at Vayam to re-learn the models. Next 15 days they made the models and taught the functioning of the models to their fellow friends. They also helped their teachers in arranging the function.

On the science day 189 students from 21 schools demonstrated in front of all younger kids.

The programmes were not big in size. There were no pandals and guests and fluent lectures on science. There was a simple and natural sharing of knowledge. It was a very good example of peer learning. That's how children really learn.

Number of ZP school	**24**
Number of Students	523
Number of Sessions	16
Frequency of the visit	Once in a week

Livelihoods Enhancement

The farming in our villages in small land holdings, mostly on degrading sloping lands, and without irrigation. Hence people after the harvesting of monsoon crop are mostly daily-wage-earners always on the verge of unemployment. This hardly gives them any extra breathing space or security that is required for a leader. Youth often aspire to get into Panchayat politics as a means of earning income.

We were seeing struggle of some newly emerging social leaders who had the will and potential to lead their villages, but not having any stable livelihood. Freeing them of daily wage worries was going to benefit the village in long run.

So, Vayam helped 29 budding entrepreneurs and social leaders from 15 villages with a new means of livelihood, a new source of income.

27 people are doing very well. Our youngest entrepreneur is just 19 years old. Ujjwala from Kashti pada learnt about food processing from VigyanAshram, Pabal. Being creative and courageous she wanted to start her own business after completing her course.

Vayam supported in her initial journey and now she is doing good on her own.

We still remember when she first came to Vayam along with her father Mohan, a Vayam Karykarta for many years, and told us about her wish to become self-dependent. It was very unusual.

We hope she prospers in her enterprise and continues to inspire her peers.

Livelihood	Number of entrepreneurs
Flour mill	9
Sugarcane juice machine	4
Bee keeping	15
Food processing	1

Su-poshan

Forest even if degraded gives so much food especially during Monsoon. Meals shrink after Monsoon considerably. Vegetables in the town market are not affordable, as travelling cost gets added. People who are not migrating and staying at home can grow vegetables for domestic use. All they need is water, seeds and saplings.

So, idea of kitchen garden emerged. Growing vegetables in Monsoon is a regular practise here. So, the idea was taken very well. Vayam has been supporting families who have joined the journey towards *Su-poshan* for 4 years. The region known outside for *Ku-Poshan* (malnutrition) will soon change its identity.

Participant families are given a good quality geomembrane, seeds, saplings and a lot of attention.

Monthly meetings and close monitoring of every Bhaji-wadi has made it possible that we could achieve average 28 kgs vegetable consumption per family during the period of three months. Families could have vegetables for three days a week. That was a lot for the families who were having vegetables for three to four times a month.

Number of Villages	28
Number of families benefitted	303
Number of vegetables	14

Celebrating plenty-ness

It is very sad when our region is known for malnutrition while our forests are full of nutrients. There are plenty of leafy vegetables, a lot more fruits and many tubers. Although having richness in quantity and diversity, nutrients are still being imported from outside. Problem is complex and so would be the solutions. So, Vayam has started a simple initiative nine years back.

In Monsoon Gramsabhas celebrate having huge and diverse wild edibles. They cook as many vegetables and eat together. There were no traditional occasions of community eating. So, Vayam introduced an idea of Forest Food Festival.

People don't sell vegetables here. They sit-eat-talk together. The festivals are not Buyer-centric market. Here people discuss why consumption has reduced, why availability has reduced, why young generation don't find taste in wild food. The discussion has led to some Gramsabha resolutions which may change the picture in the future. Journey is as interesting as reaching the destination.

Guests from cities are welcomed but festival doesn't go around them. That's why it's truly a folk-festival. You all are very much welcome coming year.

Swasth Vikas Shashwat Jal

Steep slopes and hard rocks. This what our region is. dams and farm ponds are not appropriate interventions for many of the places. Land holding is significantly low. Farmers cannot afford to spare much land for surface water storage.

Springs in the forests are small but significant source of water which is yet uncaptured everywhere. Vayam has listed all such places in the forest near 37 villages where groundwater can be found and the sources can be used for drinking and irrigation purpose if strengthened.

In last five years Vayam has developed 69 water sources in 24 villages.

This year,

It's a 'Vayam'-thing that pace and direction of any development project is decided in the Gramsabha. Nature of the work, labour, wages, period of construction all the things are decided by Gramsabha. Vayam manages the finances and takes care of the schedule once planned by Gramsabha.

Democracy is not what we talk about, but what we act upon in every aspect of our work.

Type of water body	Number of villages	Number of sources
Wells	2	2
Mini wells	2	2
Spring cordons	2	3

Gratitude

Vayam is grateful to all its supporters, well-wishers, donors, grantors. The movement is grown, has been vibrant and innovative through all 16 years of growth. The villagers who have trusted us, the field team that has toiled with courage and persistence, and our donors with their unflinching support have made this journey of grace and gratitude.

We would like to specifically thank our major grantors; Vaibbhav Ashok Goel Foundation, NOCIL Foundation, and Sirmaxo.

Thank you all! Dhanyawaad!

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